

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

COMPARATIVE POLITICS AND SOCIETIES

PIA2050 | WEEK 1: WHAT IS COMPARATIVE POLITICS?

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

THE TEXTBOOK DEFINITION

"Comparative Politics" is one of the main subfields in the social scientific discipline generally known as "Political Science."

One of the many textbooks introducing students to the subject matter (Siaroff 2022: 1-2) defines Comparative Politics as a field that focuses on the internal or the domestic politics of any country in the world.

More precisely, it entails the study of political actors (e.g., "leaders," "elites," "voters"), political institutions (e.g., "regimes," "legislatures," "federalism"), and political processes (e.g., "elections," "social movements").

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

DESCRIPTION AND EXPLANATION

"Comparativists" use evidence/observation to study actors, institutions, and processes in both:

* A "descriptive" sense (i.e., describing differences and similarities across various political systems); and in
* An "explanatory sense" (i.e., developing/testing theories that study the causes/consequences of particular outcomes/phenomena, or their variation across time/space).

Depending on how you count them, Comparative Politics is one of the three or four main subfields in Political Science.

What are the other subfields?

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

POLITICAL SCIENCE SUBFIELDS

Comparative Politics is distinguished from:

(1) Political Theory (more accurately, political philosophy);
(2) International Relations;
(3) American Politics (huh?)

What is the difference between Comparative Politics and American Politics? (Or French Politics, Korean Politics, etc.?) Meaning, aside from the volume of research published on the subject?

Substantively, none. The study of the domestic politics of any nation can be subsumed under the heading of "Comparative Politics."

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

A FIELD DEFINED BY A METHOD

Then again, there is an argument to be made that not every study of the domestic politics of a certain country qualifies as "Comparative Politics," depending on whether the research really is *comparative*.

Political scientist Giovanni Sartori called Comparative Politics "a field defined by a method" (see Sartori 1991).

Which method? The so-called "comparative method."

Sartori added that "to compare is to control." Control what? Control that generalizations made based on the study of individual countries are valid.

WHY COMPARE?

Why Compare?

Indeed, comparative *checking*. Have I not already answered my first question, namely, *Why compare*? While I am surely not the first to assert that comparisons *control* – they control (verify or falsify) whether generalizations hold across the cases to which they apply – nonetheless this is a seemingly forgotten answer. According to Przeworski, a 'consensus exists that comparative research consists *not of comparing but of explaining*. The general purpose of cross-national research is to understand . . .' (1987: 35, my emphasis). Przeworski appears to be right about the current consensus. In similar fashion Ragin (1987: 6) holds that comparative knowledge 'provides the key to understanding, explaining and interpreting'; and Mayer (1989: 12) 'redefines' (in his title) comparative politics as a field whose goal is 'the building of empirically falsifiable, explanatory theory'. Well, one can hardly disagree with an intent described as understanding and explaining; for all knowledge, none excluded, is aimed at understanding and all knowledge seeks to explain.[4] But then, why compare? What is the specific reason for being of a comparative route to knowledge? What are comparisons *for*? Against the loss of purpose that appears by now to dominate the field, let a purpose be forcefully reinstated, namely, and to repeat, that *comparing is controlling*. To be sure, one may engage in comparative work for any number of reasons; but *the* reason is control.[5]

Take the statement, 'Revolutions are caused by relative deprivation'; or the statement, 'Presidential systems are conducive to effective government, while parliamentary systems result in feeble government'. True or false? How do we know? We know by looking around, that is, by comparative checking. Granted, comparative control is but *one* method of control. It is not even a strong one. Surely experimental controls and, presumably, statistical controls are more powerful 'controllers'.[6] But the experimental method has limited applicability in the social sciences, and the statistical one requires many cases.[7] We are often faced, instead, with the 'many variables, small *N*' problem, as Lijphart (1971: 686) felicitously encapsulates it; and when this is the case our best option is to have recourse to the comparative method of control.[8] *The* reason for comparing is thus, in its basic simplicity, a compelling one. To this one may sensibly add that comparing is 'learning' from the experience of others and, conversely, that he who knows only one country knows none. Quite so.

—G. Sartori (1991: 244-5)

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

SINGLE-COUNTRY STUDIES

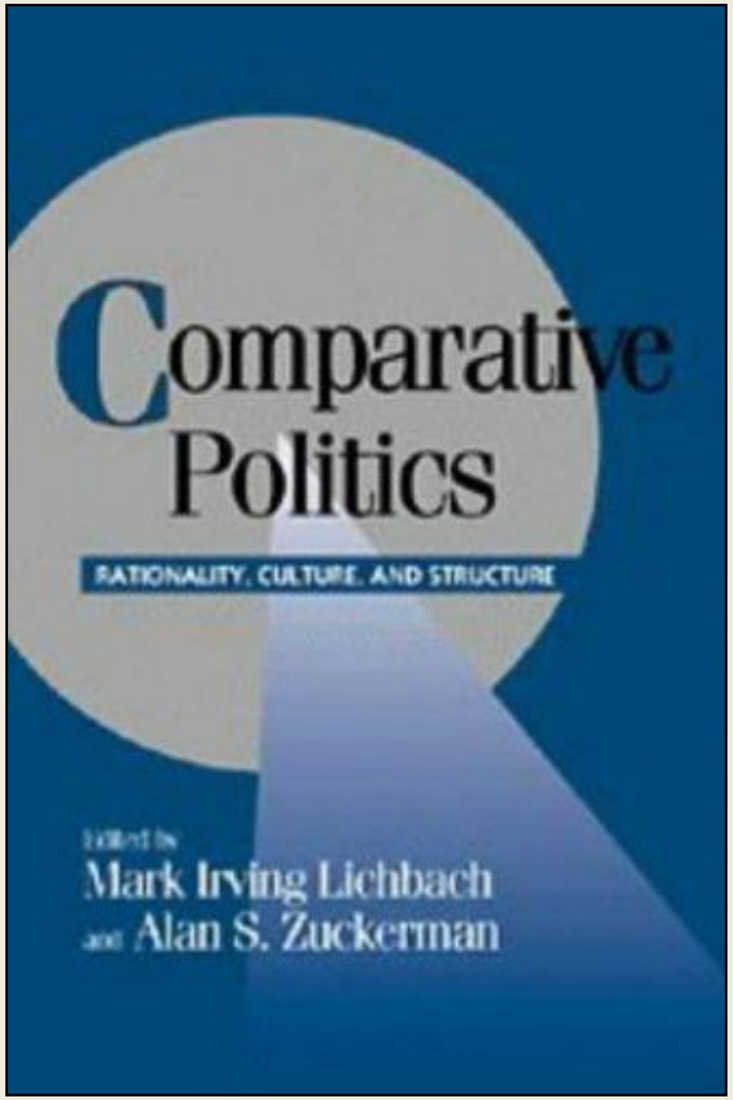
On that basis, can studies of a single country be considered works of Comparative Politics?

In principle, it is often said that single-country studies qualify as Comparative Politics as long as they are "implicitly comparative."

Meaning, if they bring theories and findings developed by the general literature to bear on the case at hand, and/or reflect on how the case at hand might inform the general literature.

Also, it's often said that historians are interested in events, while comparativists focus on classes of events, but that's not always true.

COMPARATIVE POLITICS



THE "BIG QUESTIONS"

Lichbach and Zuckerman (1997) described Comparative Politics as being characterized by:

* Ambitious scope of inquiry: no political phenomenon is foreign to it, no level of analysis is irrelevant to it, no time period is beyond its reach.
* Ambitious intellectual visions: practitioners approach events/cases with general questions in mind, not for their own sake.
* Concern for the "big questions" of social thought.

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

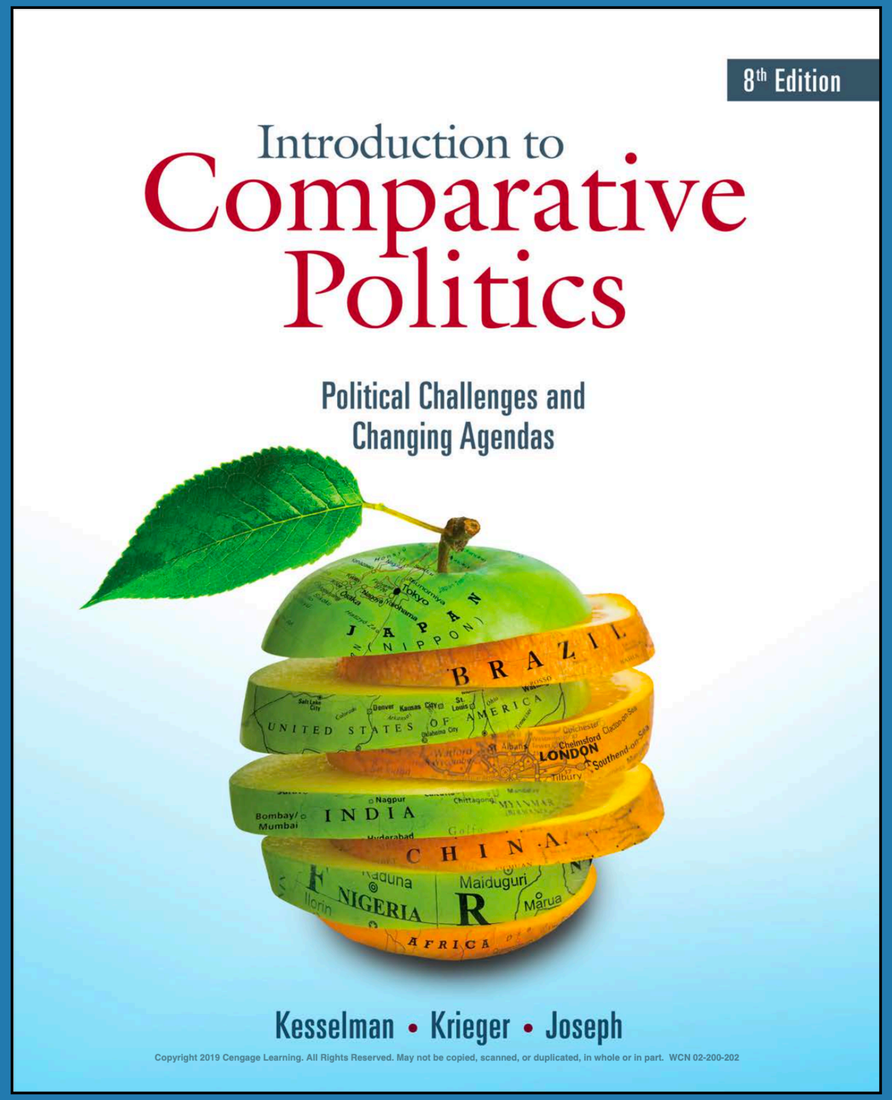
A THEMATIC APPROACH

There are at least two ways to teach Comparative Politics courses:

(1) Take a "country-based" or "country-by-country" approach:

Choose a few countries (rich/poor, democratic/non-democratic, or whatever) and focus on the structure and workings of their political systems.

This approach reflects what Comparative Politics once was—largely descriptive, legalistic, configurative—before it became a more explanatory, theoretically informed, methodologically conscious discipline focused on *real* (as opposed to formal) politics.



Brief Contents

PART I INTRODUCTION
CHAPTER 1: Introducing Comparative Politics 1

PART II CONSOLIDATED DEMOCRACIES
CHAPTER 2: Britain 38
CHAPTER 3: France 84
CHAPTER 4: Germany 133
CHAPTER 5: European Union 183
CHAPTER 6: Japan 228
CHAPTER 7: India 276
CHAPTER 8: The United States 324

PART III MIXED SYSTEMS
CHAPTER 9: Brazil 369
CHAPTER 10: Mexico 415
CHAPTER 11: South Africa 462
CHAPTER 12: Nigeria 509
CHAPTER 13: The Russian Federation 555

PART IV AUTHORITARIAN REGIMES
CHAPTER 14: Iran 607
CHAPTER 15: China 653

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An example of a country-based approach

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

THE FIELD'S PAST

Initially, Comparative Politics was preoccupied with the (descriptive) comparison of different countries' domestic legal structures.

In the 1950s, it adopted a more explanatory (causal), less formal/legalistic focus, based on the recognition that a nation's laws do NOT tell us anywhere close to the complete story of how politics works in that nation.

Also, comparativists sought/acquired greater theoretical/methodological sophistication.

Why the switch?

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

THE FIELD'S PRESENT

The main reasons for the switch:

(i) The so-called "behavioral revolution" in the social sciences coincided with greater interest in real/informal politics and greater popularity of game theory and statistical methods, while technological advances made statistical analysis more accessible to scholars and students.

(ii) Changes in geo-political context, esp. the American determination to win the Cold War (against the USSR/communism) and understand the causes of Hitler's rise/ World War II.

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

A THEMATIC APPROACH

(2) Take a “thematic” or “problem-based” approach:

Instead of proceeding country-by-country, this involves selecting particular aspects of politics/society and ask some important questions (both descriptive and explanatory) to be answered through evidence gleaned from a variety of countries/cases.

The question here is not “which country should we cover,” but rather “which general topics or themes should we include or exclude?” My courses generally focus on political institutions—their development over time as well as their effect on the behavior of relevant actors and their interactions.

THE BIG QUESTIONS

What accounts for the failure of state- and/or nation-building processes? Why are some countries democratic, while others are still ruled by despotic, authoritarian regimes? How do political institutions develop over time? How do institutions such as the form of government, the electoral system, and federalism affect a country's political life, its stability, and its prosperity? Can certain desirable outcomes be "engineered" through the design of the right institutions? What brings people to participate in politics? Why do some societies exhibit greater levels of political protest than others? What explains the intensity of the inter-group conflicts that define a country's politics? How can the rivalry between ethnic and other identity-based groups be kept from spiraling into violence? And how does a country's politics affect its levels of economic development? These questions—and others like them—will be tackled as part of this course's wide-ranging introduction to the study of comparative politics and societies.

—From the course outline

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

IN THIS COURSE

This course focuses for the most part on themes related to political institutions and regimes (configurations of institutions determining the manner in which a country is governed):

* Traditions of inquiry in Comparative Politics: How should we study the domestic politics of one and more countries? What are comparisons for, really? And what motivates/drives political behaviour?
* Political development: What is "the engine" of history? How do political institutions develop over time?

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

IN THIS COURSE

* State-formation and nation-building processes: Why do we live in a world of "nation-states"? What causes "failed states?"
* Democracy and non-democracy: What are the world's most common regimes? How can we tell if a country is a "democracy" or not? What are the major varieties of non-democratic regimes?
* Democratic transitions/authoritarian reversals: Why are some countries democratic, while others are ruled by non-democratic regimes? How do countries become democratic? And what makes democracy unstable or at risk of collapse?

COMPARATIVE POLITICS

IN THIS COURSE

* Designing political institutions: How do political institutions (form of government, electoral system, federalism) affect a country's political life, stability, and prosperity? Can desirable outcomes be "engineered" through the design of institutions?
* The wealth of nations: Why are some regions/countries rich, and others poor? What accounts for the extreme inequality we commonly observe *between* countries and *within* countries?
* Economic development and prosperity: How does a country's politics affect its levels of economic growth and development?

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